



Optimizing Decisions for an Expansion Draft

2026 Syracuse Basketball Analytics Competition



By: Jacob Andreini, Cole Verdirame, Kyle Leung, Ethan Larimore



Coin Toss

It is more valuable to obtain the **1st pick** of the Expansion Draft and the 7th pick in the rookie draft



Deep rookie class, no significant difference between picks 6 and 7

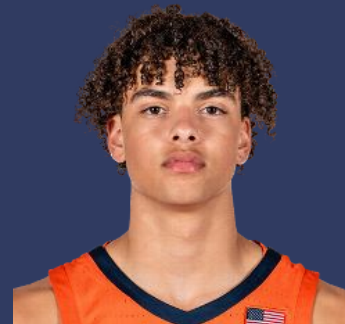
Informed strategy targeting undervalued players

2026 Draft Class

5-7 Range

First Four:

AJ Dybantsa
Darryn Peterson
Cameron Boozer
Caleb Wilson



Assume Acuff Jr. is selected 5th (elite scoring ability)

All 3 are playmaking point guards that facilitate an offense

Wagler vs Flemings

Wagler: Polished offensive game, decent size and strength



Flemings: Explosive athlete with arguably higher ceiling



Takeaway:

Value both players similarly as **primary ball handlers**
We will assume Wagler is drafted 7th overall

Player Valuation Strategy

Offense Model

Defense Model

Combined Model

Lineup Impact Model



| S | I | S |

Offense Model

Cluster players based off distribution of opportunities by play types

4 Clusters:

1. Skilled bigs
2. Ball-dominant guards and wings
3. Off-ball players and spot-up shooters
4. Secondary ball-handlers



Offense Model

Reward creating advantages (**Adv Crt+**) and good offensive process (**EPI**) across important play types

Hierarchical model to shrink
Adv Crt+



Percentile scale for both
metrics



Weigh on importance to play
type

$$\text{Total Offensive Quality} = \frac{1}{2} (\text{Scaled EPI} + \text{Scaled Adv Crt+})$$

Defense Model

Reward preventing offensive advantages across many opportunities $\rightarrow$ **Adv Prev+**



For each play type $\rightarrow$ (**Adv Prev+** $\times$ number of opportunities)
Sum the products for each play type and scale to percentiles



$$TDQ = (1/N) \sum_i (AdvPrev_{i+} \times Opps_i)$$

Combined Model

Identify unprotected players with a good process on both ends

Average unprotected players' offensive & defensive rank



Total Combined Quality = (Total Offensive Quality Rank + Total Defensive Quality Rank) / 2



Lineup Impact Model

Evaluate player contributions to **lineup EPI**
(offensively & defensively)

Hierarchical model: find players correlated
to a high lineup EPI

Random effect for surrounding **team talent** to
isolate player contributions



Undervalued Targets

Name	Combined Rank	Offensive Rank	Defensive Rank	Salary
Isaiah Joe	2	4	14	\$11,313,006
Vit Krejci	3	17	9	\$2,667,944
De'Anthony Melton	4	14	13	\$3,451,779
Craig Porter Jr.	13	34	10	\$2,406,205
Bryce McGowens	31	9	68	\$2,584,539

Big Board

1. Isaiah Joe	11. Gradey Dick	21. Tre Mann
2. Jalen Green	12. Craig Porter	22. Luke Kornet
3. Wendell Carter Jr.	13. De'Anthony Melton	23. Marcus Sasser
4. Vit Krejci	14. Dru Smith	24. Clint Capela
5. Bryce McGowens	15. Svi Mykhailiuk	25. Killian Hayes
6. Terance Mann	16. Gary Trent Jr.	26. Dalton Knecht
7. Walter Clayton Jr.	17. Bub Carrington	27. Dalen Terry
8. Brook Lopez	18. Klay Thompson	28. Mohamed Diawara
9. Spencer Jones	19. Luka Garza	29. Yuki Kawamura
10. Corey Kispert	20. Jarace Walker	30. Jaylen Clark

Expansion Draft Result



1. Isaiah Joe



6. Terance Mann



11. Gary Trent Jr.



2. Jalen Green



7. Spencer Jones



12. Corey Kispert



3. Wendell Carter Jr.



8. De'Anthony Melton



13. Dalen Terry



4. Vit Krejci



9. Brook Lopez



14. Jaylen Clark



5. Gradey Dick



10. Sviatoslav Mykhailuk



15. Yuki Kawamura

Roster Evaluation

Season Expectation: Lottery
No players who crack overall top 10 in
main models within their cluster

Goal: Form team chemistry and identity

Draft Considerations

Rotations

Starters	First Off Bench	2nd Unit
Keaton Wagler	Keaton Wagler	Jalen Green
Jalen Green	Isaiah Joe	De'Anthony Melton
Isaiah Joe	Gradey Dick	Gradey Dick/Gary Trent Jr.
Vit Krejci	Corey Kispert	Spencer Jones
Wendell Carter Jr.	Wendell Carter Jr.	Brook Lopez

Starters Playstyle

Starters

Keaton Wagler

Jalen Green

Isaiah Joe

Vit Krejci

Wendell Carter Jr.

Offense centered around Wagler and Green,
P&R with Carter Jr.

Wagler and Green both drive the ball at will,
kick to our shooters in Joe and Krejci

DHOs, flares, and stagger screens to set up
shooters

First Off Bench Playstyle

First Off Bench

Keaton Wagler

Isaiah Joe

Gradey Dick

Corey Kispert/Terance
Mann

Wendell Carter Jr.

Pace and Space offense, looking to push the tempo and run the floor

Lots of off-ball action, running Joe and Kispert off of staggers and flares

5 out spacing offense, create room for all players to attack the basket

2nd Unit Playstyle

2nd Unit

Jalen Green

De'Anthony Melton

Gradey Dick/Terance Mann

Spencer Jones

Brook Lopez

Green is the focal point, look to run P&Rs with him to create shots

Traditional offensive set, potential isolation action (Green, Melton, Dick)

Defensive emphasis (Melton, Jones, Lopez)

Roster Breakdown

Multi-Year: Joe, Carter Jr., Mann, Kispert, Mykhailuk, Krejci

1-Year / Expiring: Melton, Lopez, Trent Jr., Dick

Two-ways : Terry, Clark, Kawamura

UFA: Jones

Long-Term Pieces: Green, Wagler

Key Risks:

1-Year Deal Walk Risks (Dick, Lopez)

Wagler's and future rookies' performance uncertainty in expanded roles

Mitigants:

Remain active in free agency with competitive salary cap flexibility.

Leverage strong veteran presences (Melton, Green) to fill Wagler's role.

Salary Commitments

Season	Roster	Soft Cap Threshold	Total Allocations	1st Apron Space	2nd Apron Space
2026-27	16	\$109.9 M	\$138.9 M	\$70.1 M	\$83.1 M
2027-28	9	\$132 M	\$115.1 M	\$93.9 M	\$106.9 M
2028-29	2	\$165 M	\$30.2 M	\$178.8 M	\$191.8 M

1st Apron Threshold: **\$209,000,000**

2nd Apron Threshold: **\$222,000,000**

Kawamura, Clark, Terry given 2-way player contracts

Spencer Jones extended to multi-year deal

Las Vegas Tax Advantage

Take-Home Salary on \$50M Market contract (federal, state, local, jock tax)

Market	Take-Home %	Take-Home \$	Left on Table
Las Vegas (NV)	61.5%	\$30.75M	Baseline
Los Angeles (CA)	55.35%	\$26.68M	-\$4.08M
Toronto (Canada)	52.82%	\$26.41M	-\$4.34M
Seattle (post-2028)	56.55%	\$28.28M	-\$2.48M

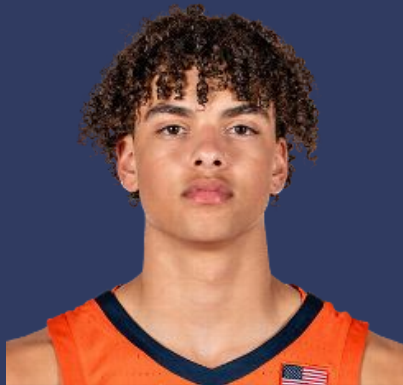
2027-28 Strategy



Overall strategy: Resign younger, high-upside contributors for near future

Multi-Year Outlook:

High-End Priority



With 100M+ in 2nd Apron Space, begin committing to long-term stars entering free agency within the next 3 years

Multi-Year Outlook:

High-End Role Players



Complement existing core with veteran role players to open the contention window

Conclusion

Modeled player talent through clustering, scaling, & hierarchical modeling

Analyzed salary cap to guide smart free agent signings

Constructed a multi-year outlook to guide Vegas to a future championship



Questions?